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Hamish the Highland Cow

A shaggy, sturdy Highland cow with a flattened brow, a wide cream muzzle and a weather-beaten fringe. Worked in pieces so every proportion can be pinned and checked before sewing.

US terms

Intermediate

6 - 8 hours



FINISHED SIZE

- About 15 cm (6 in) sitting in worsted weight.
- A 70 mm wide body and a 70 x 67 mm head.
- A low, sprawling Highland sit.

Design Code NS 01

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PATTERN OVERVIEW

A shaggy, sturdy Highland cow with a flattened brow, a wide cream muzzle and a weather-beaten fringe. Worked in pieces so every proportion can be pinned and checked before sewing.

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SAFETY FIRST

Hamish has two 12 mm safety eyes - small parts. Reach through the open head and lock the washers firmly from the inside BEFORE you stuff and close the head (Rnd 16) - once closed you cannot get back inside. Pull-test each eye. The horns, ears, muzzle, legs and tail are sewn on, and the fringe and tail are knotted yarn: sew every seam twice, weave ends in at least 5 cm, and knot the fringe and tail securely.

Not tested to ASTM F963 or EN 71 - do not describe finished Hamishes as "baby-safe". For children under three, embroider the eyes with black floss instead of safety eyes.

MATERIALS

- Yarn A - Ginger: worsted / aran (#4), about 25 g used. Caramel, toffee or ginger gold. One 80 g / 150 m ball covers several cows and re-dos.
- Yarn B - Oat cream: worsted / aran (#4), about 12 g. Muzzle, horns, inner ears, optional belly patch.
- Yarn C - Dark chocolate: worsted / aran (#4), about 5 g. Hooves and nostrils.
- Yarn D - Rust (optional): about 6 g for the scarf, or 28 cm of 12 mm tartan ribbon.
- Hook: 3.5 mm (US E-4) - smaller than the ball band so stuffing cannot show.
- Eyes: 2 x 12 mm black safety eyes, or embroider for under-threes.
- Stuffing & notions: polyester fibre fill about 30 g (buy 50 g to over-stuff the base); stitch marker, tapestry needle, pins, scissors.

GAUGE

Gauge: 11 sc x 12 rounds = 5 cm / 2 in in Yarn A. Not critical, but loose tension lets stuffing show - drop half a millimetre if your fabric is gappy.

Finished size: about 15 cm / 6 in sitting.

ABBREVIATIONS

MR magic ring
ch chain
sl st slip stitch
sc single crochet
hdc half double crochet

inc increase (2 sc in one st)
dec invisible decrease
BLO back loop only
FO fasten off
(n) stitch count at round end

CONSTRUCTION & TECHNIQUES

Work in a continuous spiral unless a round says join. Mark the first stitch of every round. Leave 30-40 cm tails on every piece you will sew.

1. The magic ring

Wrap yarn around two fingers, insert the hook, pull up a loop and work the first round into the ring; pull the tail tight once the round is complete.

2. Working in a spiral

Do not join and do not chain 1 between rounds. Move the marker up each time - there is no join to count from.

3. The invisible decrease

Insert the hook through the FRONT loops only of the next two stitches, yarn over and pull through both, then yarn over and pull through the remaining two. Every dec is worked this way - no ridge on visible rounds.

4. Back loop only (BLO)

Work into the far loop only, leaving the near loop unused; the unused loops form a raised ridge. Hamish's hoof line is one BLO round.

5. Working around a chain

For the belly patch, crochet into both sides of a starting chain: across the front, corner increases into the last chain, then back along the opposite side - turning a chain into a flat oval.

6. The lark's head knot

Fold a strand in half, push the folded loop under a stitch with the hook, pull the two loose ends through the loop and cinch. Used for every fringe strand and the tail.

7. Ladder stitch

The invisible seam: out on one side, pick up one bar on the opposite side, then one bar back, alternating, pulling snug every few stitches. The head-to-body join needs two full passes.

INSTRUCTIONS

1. Head - Yarn A

Worked from the crown down toward the neck. One straight round only - that is what keeps the brow flat and wide instead of egg-shaped. Close to 6 stitches at the end.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	-
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	-
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	fringe row 3
R7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	(42)	fringe row 2 / horns
R8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	(48)	fringe row 1 / ears
R9	sc in each st around	(48)	eyes at R9 - R10

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R10	[6 sc, dec] x 6	(42)	-
R11	[5 sc, dec] x 6	(36)	-
R12	[4 sc, dec] x 6	(30)	lock eye washers, then stuff firmly
R13	[3 sc, dec] x 6	(24)	-
R14	[2 sc, dec] x 6	(18)	-
R15	[sc, dec] x 6	(12)	last pinch of stuffing
R16	dec x 6	(6)	close the hole

Eyes & head size: place the 12 mm eyes between Rnds 9 and 10, 7 stitches apart and a touch low on the face (7 sts is about 32 mm, just under half the head width). LOCK THE WASHERS at about Rnd 12, while you can still reach the inside: press each washer on until it clicks. The head stays open until Rnd 16 closes it - after that the washers are unreachable. Finished head about 70 mm wide x 67 mm tall.

2. Muzzle & nostrils - Yarn B

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	-
R5	sc in each st around	(24)	face at full width, 35 mm
R6	sc in each st around	(24)	-
R7	sc in each st around	(24)	-
R8	[2 sc, dec] x 6	(18)	rim = 26 mm across

Finish: FO with a 40 cm tail and stuff lightly. The muzzle FACE is about 35 mm across (the wide cream patch you see); the RIM it sews by is about 26 mm, spanning roughly six rounds of head. Pin the top edge just under the eyes at Rnd 10 and let the lower edge fall at Rnd 15-16 near the chin. Centre it, let the face sit a little wider than the eye spacing, and sew with small whip stitches, adding a whisper more stuffing before you close.

Nostrils (Yarn C): two short vertical satin stitches, 3 stitches apart, on the lower third. Mouth: one tiny horizontal stitch or a shallow V below them. (The eye washers were already locked before the head was closed at Rnd 16.)

The wide cream muzzle, low-set eyes and shaggy fringe give the Highland stare.

3. Body - Yarn A

Worked bottom up. The neck is left open at 18 stitches for the head join.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	[2 sc, inc] x 6	(24)	-

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R5	[3 sc, inc] x 6	(30)	-
R6	[4 sc, inc] x 6	(36)	-
R7	[5 sc, inc] x 6	(42)	-
R8	[6 sc, inc] x 6	(48)	front legs join R8 - R9
R9	sc in each st around	(48)	-
R10	sc in each st around	(48)	body at full width, 70 mm
R11	sc in each st around	(48)	-
R12	sc in each st around	(48)	-
R13	sc in each st around	(48)	-
R14	[6 sc, dec] x 6	(42)	-
R15	sc in each st around	(42)	-
R16	[5 sc, dec] x 6	(36)	-
R17	[4 sc, dec] x 6	(30)	stuff firmly, pack the base
R18	[3 sc, dec] x 6	(24)	-
R19	[2 sc, dec] x 6	(18)	leave neck OPEN

Finish: FO with a 40 cm tail; do not close. Body is about 19 rounds (79 mm); with the head seated on the neck ring the finished sitting height is about 15 cm / 6 in.

4. Belly patch - Yarn B (optional)

A flat oval worked around a chain, sewn on last.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
Found	ch 9	-	-
R1	sc in 2nd ch, sc in next 6, 3 sc in last ch, sc in next 6, 2 sc in last loop	(18)	-
R2	inc, 6 sc, inc x 3, 6 sc, inc x 2	(24)	-
R3	sc, inc, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x 3, 6 sc, [sc, inc] x 2	(30)	-
R4	2 sc, inc, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x 3, 6 sc, [2 sc, inc] x 2	(36)	-

Sl st, FO with a long tail; sew centred on the front with the lower edge about 3 rounds up from the base. Skip it for a plain ginger front - both are correct.

5. Legs - start with Yarn C, change to Yarn A (make 4)

All four identical; the sitting pose comes from where and at what angle you sew them. Sixteen rounds = a 67 mm leg.

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR (Yarn C)	(6)	hoof
R2	inc in each st around	(12)	-
R3	[sc, inc] x 6	(18)	-
R4	sc in each st around	(18)	-

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R5	sc in each st around	(18)	-
R6	BLO sc around	(18)	change to Yarn A - ridge
R7	sc in each st around	(18)	-
R8	[sc, dec] x 6	(12)	stuff hoof firmly
R9	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R10	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R11	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R12	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R13	sc in each st around	(12)	upper leg light
R14	[2 sc, dec] x 3	(9)	-
R15	sc in each st around	(9)	-
R16	sc in each st around	(9)	leave top open

Leg length - read before you sew. A 67 mm leg joins much lower than it is long, so it splays: front about 55 degrees from vertical, back about 68-70 degrees (near horizontal) - that is the low Highland sit. For a tidier upright sit, work the FRONT pair only to Rnd 10 (42 mm); leave the back pair at 16 rounds as haunches.

6. Ears - make 2 of each layer

INNER ear - Yarn B (make 2) & OUTER ear - Yarn A (make 2)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	6 sc in MR	(6)	-
R2	[sc, inc] x 3	(9)	-
R3	[2 sc, inc] x 3	(12)	-
R4	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R5	sc in each st around	(12)	-
R6	[2 sc, dec] x 3	(9)	-
R7	sc in each st around	(9)	-

Work BOTH layers through all 7 rounds. FO the inner ear with a short tail; FO the outer with a long tail. Lay the inner on the outer, cream side facing you, and join them around the edge: either single crochet around the edge through both layers in Yarn A (about 1 sc per stitch, plus extras at the corners), or whip-stitch around with the outer's tail. Flatten and pinch the base with 2-3 stitches so the ear cups forward.

7. Horns - Yarn B (make 2)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R1	4 sc in MR	(4)	-
R2	[sc, inc] x 2	(6)	-
R3	sc in each st around	(6)	-
R4	sc in each st around	(6)	-
R5	[2 sc, inc] x 2	(8)	-

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
R6	sc in each st around	(8)	-
R7	sc in each st around	(8)	stuff tip only

FO with a tail; stuff the tip only. Short and slightly curved - tilt each horn out and a little back when you sew.

8. Tail - Yarn A

Cut 6 strands of Yarn A, each 22 cm / 8.5 in. Fold the bundle in half and attach with a lark's head at the centre-back just above the last increase round: pull the folded loop through a stitch, then the tails through the loop. Folding gives 12 hanging ends; divide into 3 groups of 4, braid 4 cm, knot firmly and trim into a small tassel.

9. Fringe - Yarn A

Attach AFTER the horns and ears so you can part the hair around them. Cut 44 strands, each 14 cm / 5.5 in (swap 6 for Yarn C for depth). Attach with lark's head knots in a horseshoe from one ear, across the brow, to the other, filling three rows across the front of the head: every stitch along the front of Rnd 8 (24 knots), then every other stitch along the front of Rnd 7 (about 10 knots) and Rnd 6 (about 9 knots) - about $24 + 10 + 9 = 43$ knots.

Tousle, then trim so the fringe grazes the eyes and breaks into uneven points. Highland hair is weather-beaten, not a salon fringe.

10. Tartan scarf - Yarn D (optional)

Rnd	Instruction	Sts	Note
Found	ch 61	-	-
Row 1	hdc in 2nd ch from hook and in each ch across	(60)	-
Row 2	ch 1, turn, hdc across	(60)	-

FO; add a 3-strand tassel at each end or weave a second colour as a slip-stitch stripe to hint at tartan, then tie loosely under the muzzle. Ribbon shortcut: 28 cm of 12 mm rust tartan ribbon, knotted once.



On the hook - what your rounds should look like as they grow

FINISHING & ASSEMBLY

- Assembly - work in this order:
 1. Muzzle & face sewn (section 2) - the eye washers were locked before the head was closed at Rnd 16.
 2. Horns between Rnds 5 and 7, 6 stitches apart, angled out and slightly back.
 3. Ears just outside and below each horn, centred on Rnds 8-9, cupped forward.
 4. Fringe attached and trimmed (section 9), parting around horns and ears.
 5. Head to body: closed head on the open 18-st neck ring (Rnd 19). Ball-on-ring join - pack the neck firmly, ladder-stitch around TWICE, tilt the muzzle slightly down.
 6. Back legs: lower sides across Rnds 3-6, almost on the base, splayed near horizontal.
 7. Front legs: FRONT across Rnds 8-9, about 8 sts apart, angled forward about 55 degrees.
 8. Belly patch - only if you made it.
 9. Tail & scarf: attach the tassel tail, tie the scarf, weave in every end and fluff the fringe.

TROUBLESHOOTING

- **He will not sit.**

Restuff the body base firmly and sew the back legs lower and wider - closer to horizontal than you think.
- **Front hooves float.**

Sewn too high - they belong on Rnds 8-9, not under the neck. If they still float, the legs are too long: work the front pair to Rnd 10.
- **Stuffing shows.**

Drop half a hook size, or hold a matching thread with the yarn on visible rounds.

- **Face looks blank.**

The eyes are too high. Low eyes plus a wide muzzle is the Highland stare.

- **Fringe is sparse.**

Add a fourth row behind the horns and mix in one darker shade.

- **Horns flop.**

Under-stuffed at the tip, or sewn only at the edge - stitch a full round into the head fabric.

- **Head tips forward.**

The neck ring grips the head only about 8 mm up. Pack the neck before closing and make the second ladder-stitch pass tight.

COLORWAYS



Ginger



Caramel



Highland black



Cream



Roan red

HELPFUL TIPS

Three sizes, one pattern

Version	Yarn / hook	Eyes	Height
Wee Hamish	DK / #3 - 2.75 mm	8-9 mm	~12 cm
Classic	Worsted / #4 - 3.5 mm	12 mm	~15 cm
Cuddle Hamish	Bulky chenille / #5 - 5.0 mm	16-18 mm	~21 cm

Stitch counts stay the same; only yarn, hook and stuffing change. Yarn scales with the square of the height and stuffing with the cube - buy generously for the big chenille version.

- Why the legs join so low: back legs (16 rnd, 67 mm, sewn to Rnds 3-6) and front legs (sewn to Rnds 8-9) splay at the checked angles so all four hooves land level. This low join is the most common failure on sitting Highland cows.
- Bottom-heavy by design: stuff the lower body firmly and keep the shape squat. Hamish is meant to settle onto his base and stare.

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Safety reminder

This pattern has not been tested to a toy-safety standard (ASTM F963 / EN 71) and uses 12 mm safety eyes and knotted yarn fringe. Finished items made for sale must be assessed by the seller against local toy-safety laws; for young children, embroider the eyes and secure every seam and knot.

Happy crocheting!

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